Literature: Poetry

H 1800

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A. Recent revisions

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

B. General rule

For collections of poetry, assign as many headings as necessary to bring out both the form and the topic(s). For single poems, assign headings as required to bring out topic(s), but assign form headings only as noted in section E, below.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Poetry***, ***Free verse***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Group Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***.

C. Designating the form of collections

C.1. General rule

Bring out the form of a collection by assigning headings of the type ***American poetry--20th century***; ***College verse***; ***Epic poetry***; etc., as in the first heading in the following example

Example:

```
Title: Maine lines; 101 contemporary poems about Maine.
   650 #0 $a American poetry $y 20th century.
   650 #0 $a Maine $x Description and travel $v Poetry.
```

LC practice:

```
   650 #0 $a American poetry $y 20th century.
   650 #0 $a Maine $x Description and travel.
   655 #7 $a Poetry. $2 lcgft
```

Certain phrase headings combine both form and topical aspects into one heading, for example, ***War poetry, English***. These headings are used to designate both the form and the topic of collections, and no additional heading is usually required.

Do not use a phrase heading of this type if a more specific ***[topic]--Poetry*** heading can be formulated to designate the topic of the collection. Instead, assign the more specific heading in conjunction with a broader, non-topical, form heading.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivision ***--Poetry***. Instead, assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Poetry*** or ***Free verse***.

For example, assign the following headings to a collection of English poetry about the Atlantic Ocean:

Example:

```
   650 #0 $a English poetry.
   650 #0 $a Atlantic Ocean $v Poetry.


   [not 650 #0 $a Sea poetry, English.]
```

```
[not 650 #0 $a Sea poetry, English.
     650 #0 $a Atlantic Ocean $v Poetry.]
```

LC practice:

```
650 #0 $a English poetry.
650 #0 $a Atlantic Ocean.
655 #7 $a Sea poetry. $2 lcgft
```

C.2. Collections of poems by one author

As a general rule, assign form headings

a. if the form heading includes a topical aspect, for example, ***Sea poetry, English***; ***Love poetry, Cuban***; ***War poetry, French***, or
b. if it is readily apparent from a cursory examination of the work being cataloged that it comprises poems of a highly specific form and that this form is an essential point of the collection, for example, ***Sonnets, American***; ***Concrete poetry, German***; etc.

Do not assign nonspecific form headings to collections of poems by one author, for example, ***American poetry***; ***Spanish poetry***.

Do not attempt to assign a form heading to a collection of poems by one author if the form is not stated on the title page or in another prominent location.

C.3. Collections of children's poetry

Assign the heading ***Children's poetry*** or ***Children's poetry, American, [English, etc.]*** to collections of children's poems, whether by one author or several authors, in addition to the other required form and topical headings.

Example:

```
Title: Tomie dePaola's book of poems.
650 #0 $a Children's poetry, American.
650 #0 $a Children's poetry, English.
```

LC practice:

```
650 #0 $a Children's poetry, American.
650 #0 $a Children's poetry, English.
655 #7 $a Poetry. $2 lcgft
385 ## $a Children $2 lcdgt
```

D. Designating the topic(s) of collections by one or several authors

Bring out identifiable topics, using one of the following types of headings, using one of the following types of headings listed in sections D.1-D.2, below.

Do not attempt to discern topics which have not been made explicit by the author or publisher, or which could be interpreted as representing value judgments.

D.1. [topic]--Poetry or [topic]--Juvenile poetry.

Use headings of this type as the standard means of designating topics in poetry, for example, ***Horses--Poetry***; *** Washington, George, 1732-1799--Juvenile poetry***; ***Callahan family--Poetry***.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Poetry*** or ***--Juvenile poetry*.** Instead, assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Poetry***, ***Free verse***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***, ***Teenagers***, etc.

Example:

Title: I could pee on this : and other poems by cats.

650 #0 $a Cats $v Poetry.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Cats.

655 #7 $a Poetry. $2 lcgft

Example:

Title: A universe of rainbows : multicolored poems for a multicolored world.

650 #0 $a Children's poetry, American.

650 #0 $a Rainbows $v Juvenile poetry.

650 #0 $a Colors $v Juvenile poetry.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Children's poetry, American.

650 #0 $a Rainbows.

650 #0 $a Colors.

655 #7 $a Poetry. $2 lcgft

385 ## $a Children $2 lcdgt

D.2. Phrase headings with topical aspects

If a phrase heading has both form and topical aspects, assign only the one heading to designate both form and topic, as described in section C.1, above. ***Historical poetry***, ***Love poetry***, and ***Political poetry*** are examples of such headings.

Example:

```
Title: Hour of freedom : American history in poetry.
   650 #0 $a Historical poetry, American.
   651 #0 $a United States $x History $v Poetry.
```

LC practice:

```
   650 #0 $a Historical poetry, American.
   651 #0 $a United States $x History.
   655 #7 $a Historical poetry. $2 lcgft
```

E. Individual poems

Bring out the topic of an individual poem by assigning headings of the type described in section D, above. Assign a form heading only if it includes a topical aspect, or if the poem is of a highly specific form, for example, ***War poetry, American***, ***Humorous poetry, Chinese***; ***Nursery rhymes, Spanish***.

Assign the heading ***Children's poetry, American, [English, etc.]*** to individual children's poems in addition to the required topical heading(s).

Do not assign topical headings to single poems which deal with vague and general topics, such as fate, mankind, belief, malaise, etc.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Poetry*** or ***--Juvenile poetry*.** Instead, assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Poetry***, ***Free verse***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***, ***Teenagers***, etc.

Example:

```
Title: And, too, the fox.
   650 #0 $a Children's poetry, American.
   650 #0 $a Foxes $v Juvenile poetry.
```

LC practice:

```
   650 #0 $a Children's poetry, American.
   650 #0 $a Foxes.
```

```
655 #7 $a Animal poetry. $2 lcgft
655 #7 $a Picture books. $2 lcgft
385 ## $a Children $2 lcdgt
```

F. History and criticism

F.1. General rule

For works about particular themes in poetry, assign as many headings as necessary to bring out the form (with subdivision ***--History and criticism***) and the topics (normally using headings of the type ***[topic] in literature***).

Examples:

```
650 #0 $a English poetry $y 20th century $x History and criticism.
650 #0 $a Mysticism in literature.
```

If a heading has both form and topical aspects, assign only the single heading with the subdivision ***--History and criticism***, for example, ***Sea poetry--History and criticism***.

F.2. Poetry about individual persons or families

For criticism of poetry about particular individuals or families, including dynasties and royal houses, assign the name of the person or family with the free-floating subdivision ***--In literature***.

Examples:

```
600 10 $a Columbus, Christopher $x In literature.
600 30 $a Lincoln family $x In literature.
```

F.3. Poetry about individual corporate bodies, places, and sacred works

For criticism of poetry about particular corporate bodies, places, or sacred works, assign the name of the entity with the free-floating subdivision ***--In literature***.

Examples:

```
610 20 $a Jesuits $x In literature.
651 #0 $a Chesapeake Bay (Md. and Va.) $x In literature.
630 00 $a Bible $x In literature.
```

F.4. Poetry about wars and similar events

For works about the poetry of a specific war, revolution, uprising, etc., assign ***[name of event]--Literature and the war, [revolution, uprising, etc.]*** as a topical heading (cf. H 1200).

Examples:

```
651 #0 $a Spain $x History $y Civil War, 1936-1939 $x Literature and the
       war.
650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $x Literature and the war.
```

F.5. Single poems

For works about a single poem with a special theme, assign a heading for the poem as well as a heading for the theme.

Example:

```
600 10 $a Smith, John. $t Scenes of Ireland.
651 #0 $a Ireland $x In literature.
```

Revision history

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.